

the British created India by unifying disparate regions and putting in place democratic institutions. It is certainly true that 'India', as a single nation-state, emerged within the modern world order of nations as a consequence of the struggle against colonial rule. It is also true that the parliamentary system of government adopted by the Constitution of the new Republic of India drew on the British model. But the conclusion that India is, therefore, beholden to British rule (and some Indians too believe this) is illogical. Firstly, it assumes that yoking together diverse kingdoms under a unifying rubric was the aim of colonial rule rather than a military, commercial and administrative convenience. (Dispatching the clichéd claim that colonial administrations united colonised peoples by building railways, the Guyanese liberation activist, Walter Rodney, observed pointedly that the British did not build them in the first instance so that Africans or Indians could go visit their friends.) In fact, neither during the freedom struggle nor since has there been consensus that the yoke of a single nation-state is an unambiguous good—even if it opened up new historical possibilities.

What unifies India? Paradoxically perhaps, those very trenchant traditions of debate and inquiry that my Chinese friend admires, predating the British and yet flourishing today, though not without obstacles. These traditions have ensured that the idea of India (to use Sunil Khilnani's phrase) has always generated discussion and scrutiny. At its best, 'India' has been a shared posing of a question rather than a single restrictive answer. Though 'unity' was very much in the minds of those involved in the freedom struggle as they sought to make common cause in the face of subjection, they necessarily found themselves reflecting on the meaning of the term. Who benefits from the unification of disparate communities? To whom does the pronoun refer in 'we, the people of India'? Whose history is Indian history? How can diverse religions, languages and cultures be brought under a single nation-state without marginalising some community somewhere? As the narrator in Rushdie's elegiac post-Babri Masjid novel, *The Moor's Last Sigh*, observes, even familiar political categories can obscure smaller entities: 'Majority, that elephant, and her sidekick, Major-Minority shall not crush my tale beneath her feet'. Stretching from Granada to Cochin, Bombay and Ayodhya, with Christians, this tale has Portuguese, Jews, Moors, communists and a party much like the Shiv Sena—all part of an insistently 'Indian yarn'.

A similar sense of vast historical and cultural reach also influenced those trying to grapple with the concept of an Indian nation in the early 20th century. Writing in 1908, Rabindranath Tagore made an impassioned call for diverse groups to cohere but was clear that he was not 'counselling that superficial unity, which is the result of the denial or the sacrifice of differences'. Unity should not mean the imposition of a single agenda, for Hindu, Muslim or Westerner to 'finally plant the standard of permanent possession' on India. Interestingly, Tagore also saw 'opposition' and dissent as essential to arriving at collective self-understanding. Even Gandhi, who in *Hind Swaraj* insisted that India possessed a civilisational unity long before the British arrived, warned against simply mirroring the practices of European nation-states, 'English rule without Englishmen'. Though a devout Hindu, he insisted that religion and nationality were not synonymous. This is why those who would reduce the nation to some simplistic religious formula have never been comfortable with either great man.

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A well-known British journalist once asked me a rather peculiar question: wasn't the empire a good thing since it had made Britain more multicultural? He was referring to the fact that in the wake of colonialism, many from Britain's colonies and former colonies relocated to that kingdom. Many, of course, had been brought there or to other British colonies as cheap or indentured labour. Today, Britain is an unmistakably multi-ethnic society, compelled to engage with its colonial past. As the defiant anti-racist slogan goes, 'We are here because you were there!' Assessing the empire as beneficial because it 'made' a nation more multicultural stands history on its head. It would mean that relatively homogeneous polities like Norway might need to rush out and colonise a few places so that they can inject themselves with a dose of multiculturalism.

India is, of course, constitutively multicul-